

a lot of the illicit transactions are directed to. The whole 113 page report is available for download in exchange for your personal details. A very interesting read!

On a much smaller scale, and far less criminal than people laundering millions of dollars, is the ability for influencers to accept payments in crypto currencies instead of traditional methods, which will allow them to get paid for promotions that they do not have to mark as promotions. On social media sites, when this starts happening, the content becomes less trustworthy, and veers towards marketing, which is not what people like as a general rule.

Social media's relation with crypto doesn't just revolve around influencers. There's also the problem of trading on social media, which, depending on which country you are a citizen of, can be against the law. This poses problems for brands like Facebook or Twitter, because someone in the EU could be wanting to sell bitcoin (perfectly legal) and someone from Nepal might make an offer to buy (illegal in Nepal). If this discussion, negotiation and transaction happens on a social media platform, the Nepalese government can demand that the social media platform ban trading or discussions about it, and even demand details to the transaction because a law was broken. This would mean revealing data about the seller to the Nepalese government as well, which according to EU law is illegal. These are the kinds of problems social media companies deal with on a regular basis, and why so many of their rules seem ridiculous to so many people.

Social media are also the ones usually responsible for spreading news about something, and this could be news about cryptocurrencies that can cause huge fluctuations in the prices, and thus lose a lot of people a lot of money. Since crypto is a hot topic, and usually discussed on social media or popular messaging apps, the risk of some fake news causing a massive change in crypto prices is a scary prospect indeed – crypto being decentralised and not

backed by any government or bank is scary enough without adding more factors into the equation!

DISINFORMATION AND DEEP FAKES

Which brings us to a larger discussion about disinformation and fakes, which trolls on the internet love to spread. Twenty years ago, most of us thought the internet would be



Fans used deepfake tech to improve the appearance of Princess Leia in *Rogue One*

mankind's greatest ever achievement for at least the next 300 years or so. The age of information being spread to every corner of the globe was a mind-bogglingly complicated sea of possibilities. Who knew it would all lead up to people spreading disinformation and lies.

This is a huge problem for social media, because they will always be expected to clamp down on disinformation. Then again, the problem is that when governments get involved, disinformation is often defined on who is being maligned rather than what actually is false information. An ex-President of the US was famous for shouting "You are fake news!" at journalists who did not report on him favourably, and it was something that his followers would also be quick to claim. With journalism being so *ugh* politicised and so obviously biased there, it's almost impossible at times to find what the actual news really is. And since almost all of these services need to be a hit in the US before they're accepted globally, they are inherently tainted with this political bent for everything.

Deep fakes, on the other hand, are the plague of famous people, but this is fast changing to become a problem for just any one of us in the future. Pretty soon just about anybody with access to pictures of you can start making videos of you doing things you absolutely did not do. While the mobile app versions of this technology are very funny looking and don't look that realistic,

there are solutions out there that those who are serious about the technology can make good use of, for a fee. In a place like India where perception often far outweighs reality, we will not at all be surprised when we start reading about people making deep fakes of their competitors as a way of maligning them. And we're not talking about politicians playing dirty as usual, we're talking about one of your colleagues who is vying for the same promotion as you making a deep fake of you kicking a puppy, or something much worse, and then "leaking" it to malign your reputation so that he gets the job instead... Yes, that's the level of fakery coming your way in under 10 years. How will your social media habits change then? Perhaps, as our headline suggests, you will go more micro-social instead of macro-social in sharing things, especially photos and videos.

AFFILIATE / SOCIAL SHOPPING

A lot of internet pundits have predicted that social commerce (selling on social media) is the future of all